TRT 19

Tribulus terrestris

Puncture vine, a plant used in herbal medicine; contains steroidal saponins, mainly protodioscin



CLASS Plant extract

STUDIED FOR Erections, testosterone, strength

HUMAN EVIDENCE Controlled human trials; mixed results

US STATUS Dietary supplement · not an approved drug

STUDIED FOR

- **Erectile function** — HUMAN
- **Testosterone** — HUMAN + ANIMAL
- **Strength, lean mass** — HUMAN
- **Urinary symptoms** — HUMAN

Case reports of organ injury. Case reports describe kidney and liver injury and breast growth in men who used tribulus.

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

CONTROLLED TRIALS
LEVEL 4 OF 5

- Randomized trials of 21 to 180 men
- 4 to 12 weeks each
- Meta-analysis: no change in total testosterone

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Long-term safety
- Half-life in people
- Drug interactions
- Mechanism in people

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Plant extract ▶ Saponins ▶ Protodioscin ▶ Sexual function

- Effects are attributed to **steroidal saponins**, mainly protodioscin
- **In trials,** testosterone, androstenedione and LH mostly did not change
- **In people,** the mechanism is not established

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE Not established in people

ROUTES STUDIED By mouth (extract tablets) in trials

PHARMACOKINETICS Not established

SOLD AS Dietary supplement; not FDA reviewed before sale

MONITORED IN TRIALS Erectile function scores, testosterone, PSA, liver enzymes

SPORT (WADA) Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY FDA: No approved drug; sold as dietary supplement | WADA: Not listed

REFERENCES

1. Int J Impot Res, tribulus for erectile dysfunction meta-analysis, Jan 2026
2. Maturitas, tribulus in male sexual dysfunction, May 2017
3. J Strength Cond Res, tribulus in elite rugby league players, May 2007

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